

Five Habits of Highly Effective Leaders

What the most effective executives do differently and how you can start building these habits now

The best leaders aren't necessarily the smartest or hardest-working people in the room. Instead, they're the ones who've built a small set of consistent habits that compound over time around how they think, communicate, and use their energy. This guide walks through five of the habits I see most consistently in the highest-performing leaders I coach, along with a simple way to start practicing each habit this week.

Habit 1: Protect your thinking time before it disappears

High performers block real time for strategic thinking before their calendar fills with reactive meetings. Without this, leaders spend all day putting out fires and are not able to get ahead.

Try this week: Block one 45-minute slot for strategic thinking only: no email, no meetings, no "I just need a minute from you." Protect it like you would a client meeting.

Habit 2: Ask before you tell

Instead of leading with answers, effective leaders lead with small, open questions. This helps to develop their team's thinking and to avoid missing deeper context.

Try this week: In your next three 1:1s, adopt a mentoring stance. Ask "What do you want to have happen?" and listen before you offer your own view.

Habit 3: Give feedback in the moment, not just reviews

Waiting for formal reviews to address performance or behavior lets small issues become bigger ones and denies people the chance to course-correct quickly.

Try this week: The next time something needs to be said, say it within 48 hours — briefly, specifically, and directly.

Habit 4: Delegate outcomes, not tasks

Rather than handing off checklists, strong leaders delegate ownership of a result. This builds capability and frees up their own capacity.

Try this week: Pick one recurring task on your plate. Hand off the outcome, not just the steps, to someone ready to grow into it.

Habit 5: Manage your energy, not your time

Sustainable high performance comes from noticing what depletes and restores energy, not just cramming more into the calendar.

Try this week: Track your energy (high/medium/low) every two hours for three days. Notice what your pattern are before trying to fix them.

None of these habits require a personality transplant. These are small, repeatable shifts that compound over weeks and months. Pick one habit from this guide and commit to practicing it for the next two weeks before adding another. Real leadership change happens through small, consistent reps, not overnight transformation.

Want support building habits like these? I offer a complimentary consultation to see if we're a good fit as you work towards your leadership goals. Visit www.admelioracoaching.com to schedule a session.

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